The famous *Sastha* temples now existing in Sabarimala, Thakkala and other places in Travancore were originally none other than temples dedicated to Buddha. Besides these temples, several remains of Buddhist *viharas* and *chaityas* are still seen in different parts of this country. These are indications of Buddhism having been once the common religion in Travancore.'

The author of this report was not some British official but a Telugu Brahmin, Nagam Aiya, author of the three-volume *Travancore State Manual*, published in 1906. Nor was Aiya the only Brahmin to hold such scandalous views. Fifty years earlier one of Aiya's Brahmin predecessors in Travancore State had noted in another report that the Hindu temple of Chitharal, near Nagercoil, had originally been Buddhist, to which the ruler of Travancore, Maharaja Visakham Thirunal, had added his own comment: 'Your description is correct. The Brahmins have appropriated and adapted this Buddhist temple as they have done with many others. What you call *muni* is nothing but the figure of Buddha Gautama.'[1]

But the maharaja was only partly correct. The Chitharal temple he was referring to stands isolated on a rocky ridge above a bend in the Thamirabarani or Kathayar River as it winds south out of the Western Ghats to empty itself into the sea west of Nagercoil. The oldest part of the temple stands on a platform just below the summit, and at first glance it looks very like a classical Greek temple. But whatever the *Travancore State Manual* and Maharaja Visakham Thirumal had to say, this was never Buddhist. It was originally a Jain retreat in the form of a rock-shelter which was then built up into a Jain temple, only to be converted centuries later to the worship of the Hindu goddess Lakshmi.

The Hindu takeover of the Jain temple at Chitharal, whether by lapse or appropriation, was part of a process that happened all over South India over the course of some